SMALL BRAIN

Scientists once thought our ancestors evolved large brains before they mastered the tricky business of walking. But *Australopithecus* proves the opposite was true—it could walk, but its brain was barely larger than a chimp's. This animal didn't have the brainpower needed for language and couldn't talk, although individuals may have whooped and screeched to communicate.

▲ THIS RECONSTRUCTION, *based on a skull of* Australopithecus, *shows how apelike it looked. Its small braincase gave it a flat, sloping forehead quite unlike the upright forehead of modern humans.*

In 1975, scientists found fossilized remains of at least 13 *Australopithecus* bodies at the same site in Ethiopia. The find was nicknamed "the first family," although they may have been unrelated victims of predators such as lions.

LANDSCAPE AND FOOD

Today, most apes live in jungles, but *Australopithecus* lived in a more open landscape—a mixture of grassy areas and patches of trees. Its large jaws and thickly enameled molars (back teeth) show it foraged for tough, plant foods like roots and seeds, but like other apes it probably had a very varied diet that included fruit, insects, and perhaps meat.

Footprints from the past

In 1976, scientists found what looked like fossilized human footprints in Tanzania, Africa—but the prints turned out to be 3.6 million years old. They were left by a group of three *Australopithecus* walking over volcanic ash and clearly show that these animals could walk on two feet.

LIVING RELATIVE

The chimpanzee is a very close relative of *Australopithecus*. Chimpanzees sometimes use rocks and sticks as simple tools. They use rocks to crack nuts and sticks to fish termites out of their nests. It's likely that *Australopithecus* also used simple tools like these, but there's little fossil evidence that it could make the kinds of stone tools that the later humans made.